Bright. Apple. Crush.

By Steve Yockey

NANCY: **(Pgs 33-41)** Teaching is not for everyone. I'm Nancy, Nancy Miller. You might have read about me. Those kids were horrible. I can't say a single nice thing and their parents were just . . . Some people shouldn't be allowed to have children.

There was one little boy who would kick me as hard as he could. Every chance he got. I couldn't believe it. Ridiculously painful. Every day, every time, kicking me. And he was one of the better kids. If that gives you an idea of how bad they really were.

INTRODUCTION

Short workdays, smaller class sizes, long breaks – including the entire summer off. "Our schools are excellent places to work," insists our society. So why, amid reports of depression, breakdowns and suicide, is teaching now rated one of the most stressful occupations in the country?

According to Stan Gilmore of the Institute of Counseling, "Most teachers, if they are honest, will testify that at some point in their teaching career they have encountered difficulties in coping with the relentless pressure to maintain order, which has led a "mental breakdown".

And while the majority of teachers simply leave the profession in 5 years or less . . . teacher Nancy Miller stays, and her atypical breakdown becomes an extreme example of how things can go horribly wrong.

Bright. Apple. Crush by Steven Yockey

NANCY: It's hard when you decide you're really going to try and help people. Become a teacher; take a job where you can make a difference. Where you **think** you can make a difference. It's hard when that turns out to be impossible. That's frustrating. Especially when you can help a kid and they don't want it. Like they know anything. When you're trying to help a kid and they act like they're smarter than you. A bunch of ****** ten-year-olds. Like they know anything . . . Except how to be mean. No one warns you about that, in college, in your classes. Even when you're assistant teaching. No one tells you. Kids can be terrible.

FOR EDUCATIONAL

I remember so vividly the moment when I just snapped. I was at my desk. I was trying to explain photosynthesis. Well, the way you explain photosynthesis to a bunch of ten-year-olds.

(In her condescending teacher's voice) "The plants have their leaves and the sunlight shines down, bright light . . . . "

And as I'm trying to each these kids something, I'm writing on the board, with my back to them like this *(she turns and speaks over her shoulder).* And I get hit with something, hit hard on the shoulder and then again in the leg. And again, in the hip. It took me a moment to even realize what was happening. They were throwing rocks at me. These kids in my class, these young kids, were actually throwing rocks at me and laughing. I couldn't even speak. They were hitting me.

I took the rest of the day off. I went home. *(She pulls an apple from behind her back where she has been hiding it in one hand or the other . . .)* While I was at home, I had some time to think. To really thing about what happened, about everything that had happened in my three months at that school. I made some decisions. About those ***** ten-year-olds. If you can't teach them to even be human, then what good are they?

(she tosses and catches the apple) The healthiest snack in the world. I passed them out and said: *(a return to the teacher's voice)* "All right, it's important that you all stay healthy. But I know that not everyone loves to eat apples. So here's a little deal for you guys: Whoever finishes their apple first will get an extra twenty minutes at recess."

It all happened so quickly. They just started tearing into the apples. And I'll confess that it was exciting. I didn't expect them all to react with such enthusiasm for just twenty extra minutes at recess. I thought it would somehow be harder.

I might have used too much poison. If I had known they'd be so voracious, I probably would have eased off a bit. I like to think I would have been more restrained. But that might be too generous, really.

FOR EDUCATIONAL USE ONLY

It took about ten minutes before the first one started convulsing. But it happened quickly after that. I wouldn't let any of them go to the bathroom, I wouldn't let any of them leave. I told them to stay in their seats, and for the first time, and I don't know if they were afraid or disoriented or just stunned, but they did as they were told. I sat behind my desk and watched these horrible children drop to the floor or collapse onto their desks one by one in pools of spit and some crimson streaks. And they were crying and asking for help and confused. Clearly confused. It's hard for me to say this, but honestly it was a real delight to see these worthless children suffer the way that I suffered when all I wanted to do was help them become better people.

There were only one or two left mildly conscious when I even began to realize that this might cause a problem. I knew they wouldn't understand. No one. So the general reaction didn't surprise me. Maybe some of the other teachers . . . but no, no one did. But I think the other teachers were secretly proud of me.

I don't even read the papers or watch television anymore, because of the ridiculous things people are saying about me. Saying I hate children. It's amazing what people will believe. I took that job because I love kids. Those weren't kids though, you see? They were . . . . . something else.

I've been told as part of the whole court thing, that I'll be going to a hospital. Where someone will take care of me for a change. That will be nice. Healthy. Or, I don't know . . . . It doesn't matter anyway. No harm done. *(she holds out the apple . . . .)* Apple?

FOR EDUCATIONAL USE ONLY

SOURCE INFORMATION

Author: Steve Yockey
Book: Off Off Broadway Festival Plays, 32nd Series; Pgs 33-41
ISBN: 978-0573660238
Publisher: Samuel French
Date (Month/Year): Oct 2010

AWARD HISTORY

2020 National Qualifier – MS
2021 National Qualifier – MS
2022 National Qualifier – MS
2023 National Qualifeir – MS
2025 National Qualifier
NIETOC
CO State Qualifier
KS State Qualifier
MN State Qualifier

FOR EDUCATIONAL USE ONLY